

11. Fallout

Ending anyone's international career is a horrible, hateful experience. When it concerns a globally renowned, passionately admired figure you have played alongside for eight years it is uniquely uncomfortable. There is no easy way to express the hardest truth of elite sport, that everyone, to a lesser or greater degree, lives on borrowed time.

We didn't need *Wisden* to measure Kevin Pietersen's stature. Statistics, 8,181 Test runs at an average of 47.28, incorporating thirty-two hundreds for England across all forms of the game, merely hint at the majesty of the memories he created. Ultimately his personality was as integral to the decision as his waning powers of performance.

Andy Flower, as expected, had resigned as director of the Test team a couple of days earlier. Kevin had never really convinced him that he bought into the principle of being a team player without reservation. A consensus had emerged during the one-day series in Australia, and on our return home, that a statement of intent and a reaffirmation of trust were overdue.

Kevin was centrally contracted but, like all of us, had no guarantee of selection. Simply not picking him was a theoretical option, but I supported Paul Downton, the ECB's managing director. 'I don't want that cloud hanging over us,' he told James Whitaker, the national selector, and me. 'I don't want every press conference to start with the question, "*Is KP coming back?* " I don't want us to get bowled out cheaply and have everyone asking, "*Is KP coming back?* "'